CHAPTER III

The Geography of Almost

Kolkata · 11 July 2023

“There is a peculiar tenderness in remembering the person we were before certain ordinary moments changed us. How earnestly we worried over things that would one day seem so small; how carefully we rehearsed words that, when the moment arrived, came out quite differently. Perhaps memory is kindest to us in this way: it preserves not only what happened, but something of the person who stood there, uncertain of everything except the quiet wish that the afternoon might last a little longer.”

By the time the first class ended, Utkarsh had no intention of doing anything that might require courage. He had come to coaching to study, had spent the better part of the morning doing precisely that, and expected the remainder of the day to pass without incident. The Arithmetic teacher had mentioned that they would be practising questions from a PDF in the next class. Around him, chairs shifted, notebooks closed, and conversations abandoned midway resumed with remarkable urgency. Most of the students went downstairs for tea or a cigarette; even the teachers disappeared for a few minutes.

He was preparing to leave when he noticed Diya walking out with her bag. His eyes went towards Sanondita’s usual place, then back to the doorway. Sanondita wasn’t with her. He waited a moment, as though she might appear behind her friend, but she didn’t. Students left early all the time. There was nothing unusual about it. Nevertheless, on his way downstairs, he found himself wondering whether Sanondita would stay for the second class.

The break had gathered most of the coaching students into a noisy congregation. They stood in loose groups, discussing

questions they had confidently answered incorrectly. A little farther away, several teachers were smoking and talking among themselves. Utkarsh stood with Tanisha, Nikita, and Deepesh, holding a paper cup of tea that was still too hot to drink. Deepesh took a cautious sip from his own and immediately regretted it.

"What's the hurry?" Nikita asked.

"I was thirsty."

"You're drinking tea."

"I've made worse decisions."

"That," Tanisha said, "I believe."

Utkarsh laughed with the others. For a few minutes, the conversation wandered from the morning's class to the questions waiting for them in the next one. Deepesh hoped the PDF would contain fewer problems than the teacher had promised.

"You haven't even seen it," Nikita pointed out.

"Exactly. I'd like to remain optimistic while I still can."

Tanisha shook her head, smiling, and asked whether he had at least revised the previous lesson. Deepesh looked to Utkarsh for support, only to find him watching a student hurry past with a notebook beneath his arm.

"Are you listening?"

"Unfortunately," Utkarsh replied.

"Then answer her."

"I wouldn't want to interfere with your education."

Deepesh laughed and returned to defending his study habits. Utkarsh smiled too, but his attention kept slipping towards the building. He knew Sanondita generally stayed upstairs during breaks. She might be sitting there now, with the place beside her empty. He could go up before the others. He could sit somewhere near her.

He took another sip of tea and remained where he was.

There was still time. His friends were talking; he had no particular reason to leave. Perhaps someone else would take that

seat before the class began. The thought brought an unwelcome relief, followed almost immediately by irritation. Nobody would be doing anything wrong by sitting there. He would simply have allowed another person to make the decision he had been avoiding for months.

His tea had gone lukewarm. He finished it before he could settle into that relief.

"I'm going upstairs," he said, setting the empty cup aside.

"Already?" Nikita asked.

"Yeah. I'll sit for a bit."

"You've been sitting since morning," Deepesh said. "At least let your legs enjoy the break."

"They've had enough enjoyment."

"Lucky legs."

Tanisha laughed. Utkarsh shook his head and walked towards the lift, conscious of leaving earlier than he usually did. While he waited, he glanced back. Deepesh was gesturing with his cup, and Nikita appeared to be disagreeing with him. Utkarsh could return to them. Nothing required him to go upstairs yet, and nobody would ask why he had changed his mind.

The lift arrived. Two students stepped out; he moved aside, then entered and pressed the button for the coaching floor. He had not decided to speak to Sanondita. He hadn't even decided where to sit. As the doors closed, however, he hoped the classroom would still be nearly empty.

The corridor was quieter now. A few voices carried through the half-open doors, and Utkarsh walked towards his room at a pace that cost him some effort to maintain. At the doorway, he looked inside.

Sanondita was there, in her usual place towards the front-left corner, her attention lowered to the writing tablet attached to her chair. Diya's seat was vacant. The board, the rows of chairs, the bags left behind by students who had gone downstairs—everything

was familiar. He stood at the entrance long enough to notice the empty floor between himself and her.

There were plenty of places to sit. Had the room been crowded, he might have let the remaining seats decide for him. Instead, each chair seemed to require an explanation. One was too close; another was unnecessarily far away. He walked farther in, pretending to consider the arrangement with the seriousness of someone choosing a seat for an examination.

Finally, he sat several feet from Sanondita, leaving enough space for two or three chairs between them. He placed his notebook on the attached tablet and tried to fit his legs beneath it. At his height, those compact chairs were uncomfortable on an ordinary day. Now he could scarcely arrange himself at all.

Well. You're here. Now what?

He uncapped his pen. Across the gap, Sanondita continued with her own things.

The classroom began filling again. A boy dropped his bag onto a chair and went back out; two others entered arguing over an answer from the first class. Utkarsh opened his notebook to an unfinished Arithmetic calculation. He wrote a number beneath it, checked the previous line, and crossed the number out. Every time someone came through the doorway, he found himself looking towards the space beside Sanondita. He had come upstairs to study, apparently, and had accomplished less than he would have downstairs with an empty cup of tea.

Then he heard Deepesh outside.

"I'm telling you, the answer was right. The options were wrong."

"That doesn't even make sense," Nikita replied.

"It makes sense if you think about it."

"I have. That's the problem."

Tanisha caught Utkarsh's eye as they entered, then glanced at the empty chairs between him and Sanondita. Her expression changed just enough for him to notice. He gave a tiny shake of his head. She said nothing, which left him unable to tell how much she had

understood. Deepesh sat farther back, still occupied with proving a point nobody seemed interested in conceding.

Utkarsh lowered his eyes. The unfinished calculation remained unfinished. Sanondita had not looked his way, and he had not spoken to her. The second class was about to begin.

The Arithmetic teacher arrived carrying a notebook and the familiar expression of someone who expected the class to have accomplished more during the break than it had. Conversations faded.

“All right. We’ll practise the questions from the PDF today. It’s been shared in the official WhatsApp group. Check whether you’ve received it.”

Phones appeared around the room. Someone asked which group; someone else complained that the file wasn’t downloading. Utkarsh reached towards his trouser pocket, felt the outline of his phone, and stopped. Sanondita was opening the document on hers.

He could ask to see it. Students shared books and notes all the time. The request would give him something to say, and the lesson would give them a reason to continue sitting together afterward. All he needed was to have forgotten his phone.

His hand moved away from the pocket.

You could just open the PDF.

He looked at the board, where the teacher had begun writing the first question. Of all the excuses he might have found, this was a particularly foolish one. What if his phone rang? What if, forgetting himself, he took it out? He could already imagine the moment she would look from the phone to him, and how much worse explaining the lie would be than asking honestly for a conversation.

He picked up his pen anyway.

For months, he had wanted an opportunity that would spare him the embarrassment of wanting one. Even now, with Sanondita sitting only a few feet away, he preferred the risk of being caught in a small lie to letting her see why he had come upstairs early. He

turned the pen between his fingers. By evening, if he did nothing, this would become another afternoon he had almost spoken to her.

He leaned towards her, then stopped. He knew her name, but using it before they had introduced themselves might invite a question he did not want to answer. At the front, the teacher said something about time and work. Utkarsh caught the words and immediately lost the explanation that followed.

Just ask her. It's a PDF, not a marriage proposal.

He reached across the space with his pen and gave her a light nudge to get her attention. Sanondita turned. For a second, the sentence he had prepared vanished.

"Um—sorry," he began.

She waited.

"I actually…" He cleared his throat. "I forgot my phone at home."

The phone rested against his leg, its weight suddenly difficult to ignore.

"Could I—could I look at the questions on yours?"

Sanondita glanced at her screen. "Yeah, sure."

"Thanks."

He nodded too quickly. She looked at the gap between their chairs and then back at the phone. He had been so occupied with the possibility of refusal that he had neglected the practical consequences of her agreeing. From where he sat, he could read almost nothing.

For a few seconds, he considered standing up. He could lift the chair, move it closer, and sit down again. But that meant unfolding his long legs from beneath the tablet and rising to his full height while she waited. He imagined everyone looking over. Instead, he drew his feet beneath him, gripped the sides of his chair, and tried to move without getting up.

The chair stayed where it was.

He tried again, lifting his weight enough to pull it sideways. A short scrape came from beneath him. He froze, but the teacher continued explaining, and the students around him continued writing.

Wonderful. Very discreet. Perhaps drag the entire building a little closer while you're at it.

Sanondita had angled her phone towards him. He was still too far away.

"Just a second," he whispered.

He pulled in his knees and shifted another few inches. The attached tablet made it difficult to find a grip; each movement required a fresh negotiation between his feet, the chair legs, and the floor. Trying to be quiet only prolonged the journey. He could have stood up and finished it by now. Having committed himself to this method, however, he appeared determined to suffer its full consequences.

Another scrape. The whiteboard marker continued moving. He made a final adjustment and, unable to resist, glanced over his shoulder.

Tanisha was smiling. Nikita had a hand near her mouth, her eyes bright with the effort of containing a laugh. Deepesh looked directly at him without saying anything. His expression suggested that he intended to remember this for the rest of Utkarsh's natural life.

Utkarsh stared at him. Deepesh raised his eyebrows.

Don't.

Deepesh's smile widened. Utkarsh turned away before he lost control of his own, lowered his head, and bit the inside of his cheek.

Of course they saw. Why wouldn't they? You practically travelled here by furniture.

His shoulders gave a small, involuntary shake. He fixed his eyes on the PDF and drew a slow breath, trying to keep the laughter in. Then Sanondita moved the screen a little closer.

“Can you see?”

He looked at her, and for an instant forgot what had been funny.

“Yeah.” He checked the screen. “Yeah, I can. Thanks.”

She had made room for him to read. Whatever she thought of his arrival, she gave no sign of it. He looked down at the question, grateful for the uncomplicated way she had asked. There was still a comfortable gap between their chairs. Their tablets did not touch, and neither did their arms. He placed his elbow carefully within the edge of his own desk.

The teacher was explaining the next step. Utkarsh copied a number without understanding where it had come from. Beneath the desk, his right leg began shaking. He pressed his foot flat against the floor; a few seconds later, the movement returned.

He had always considered himself reasonably good at Arithmetic. Usually, he could follow a calculation without thinking about where to put his elbows or whether his breathing was audible to the person beside him. Now he read the first question from the beginning and reached the middle with no idea what the beginning had said.

Sanondita adjusted the phone again.

“Is this okay?”

“Yeah. Perfect.”

He answered before properly checking. The screen was clearer, at least. He held his eyes on it until the small smile threatening his concentration had passed, and began the question once more.

For several minutes, he attempted to become an ordinary student. He copied the same number twice, crossed one out, and checked the screen, only to discover that neither was correct. Around him, pens travelled steadily across paper. Sanondita was writing too. He glanced from her notebook to the whiteboard, trying to work out how the class had progressed so far without him.

“Sorry… Which question are we on?”

“The third one.”

“The third?”

“Yeah.”

“Oh.”

She pointed to the screen. “This one.”

“Right. Thanks.”

He had barely finished copying the first. He turned his attention to the third and tried to follow the method, aware of the crossed-out figures on his page. It would have been easier to ask another question if he hadn’t already needed help with so much. His leg trembled again; the chair gave a faint creak. He pressed his foot down.

“Are you getting it?” Sanondita asked.

“Sorry?”

“The question.”

“Oh. Yeah.”

He looked at the calculation he had abandoned halfway through.

“Not entirely.”

She gave a small smile and indicated a step in the method. “It’s this step.”

He followed where she was pointing. Once she explained it, the figures resumed their familiar relationship to one another. He could see where he had gone wrong.

“Oh. Okay. I was doing something completely different.”

He bent over his notebook. “Which explains quite a lot.”

For a while, they worked quietly. He corrected the method and carried the calculation a little farther. There was something relieving about having admitted that he didn’t understand. She hadn’t made anything of it. She had shown him the step and returned to her own work, leaving him free to finish rather than continue pretending.

He wanted to ask her something beyond the lesson. Her studies, perhaps, or whether she attended regularly. When the class ended, he would otherwise be the boy who had forgotten his phone and

required considerable assistance with Arithmetic. He could introduce himself. That was an ordinary place to begin.

Hello. I am the man who arrived by chair. Would you care to become friends?

He lowered his head to hide another smile. Perhaps not that.

By then, he had completed one question, though half the method had come from her page. At the front, the teacher turned to the board. Sanondita was finishing a line in her notebook. Utkarsh waited for her pen to stop, then found that the question he wanted to ask was one whose answer he had known since March.

“By the way… What’s your name?”

“Sanondita.”

“Oh, okay.”

He looked down. He had heard Tanisha say her name, recognised it whenever it came up, and privately repeated it more often than he would admit. Now that Sanondita had said it to him herself, he had responded as though she had informed him when the next class began.

The words I’m Utkarsh, by the way were almost ready. But she had returned to the question, and he let the moment pass. He could tell her later, when the conversation developed naturally. There was still time.

He followed the explanation for nearly a minute. Then the teacher paused to check a calculation.

“Can I ask you something?”

She turned slightly. “Hmm?”

“What did you graduate in?”

“Geography.”

“Geography?”

“Yeah.”

“Honours?”

She nodded.

“Oh, nice.”

Apparently, the English language had left him two expressions with which to manage the afternoon. He tried to think of a third.

"So you must be good at Geography."

Sanondita gave a small, noncommittal smile. "Not necessarily."

"Fair enough," he whispered. "I suppose graduating in something doesn't mean you have to know everything about it."

She returned to her notebook. He let the conversation rest and copied another line from the board. This time, he understood it. A few moments later, he looked towards her again.

"You've already graduated, right?"

"Yeah."

"Which year?"

"Last year."

"2022?"

She nodded. He briefly wondered whether she was older than him and attempted a calculation entirely unrelated to the one on the board. He didn't know her age. It hardly mattered. He returned to the question.

"What about you?"

Utkarsh looked up. "Sorry?"

"What did you study?"

For a moment, he had no answer ready. He had been choosing each question carefully, trying to find the next without giving her too many at once. He hadn't expected the conversation to come towards him.

"BBA," he said. "Bachelor of Business Administration."

"You've graduated?"

"Almost. I just finished my final-semester exams. Results haven't come yet."

"Oh, okay."

He smiled faintly. Apparently, they both spoke the same language.

He wanted to say more about college, the exams, the classes he had missed. He was pleased enough by being asked that he could easily have answered beyond anything she needed to know. Instead, he glanced at the PDF. The teacher had moved on again.

“I’m falling behind.”

“Which one are you doing?”

He showed her his notebook. She pointed to the next question.

“This one.”

“Right.” He paused. “At this rate, I might graduate again before I finish the PDF.”

He looked at the board before he could discover whether the remark had amused her. His fingers had loosened around the pen. He was still conscious of sitting near her, but now he knew what she had studied, and she knew what he had studied. There was a question of hers among all the questions he had asked. He settled his notebook on the tablet and began writing again.

For a while, Utkarsh managed to follow the lesson. The teacher drew a small table on the whiteboard and filled its columns with figures. The method seemed unnecessarily complicated until the final step made everything fall into place. Utkarsh copied the calculation, checked the question on the PDF, and arrived at an answer. Beside him, Sanondita was still working. He resisted looking at her notebook. For once, he wanted to solve something without borrowing the answer along with her phone.

The teacher asked the class what they had obtained. Several students answered at once. Their number matched his.

“Did you get it?” he whispered.

Sanondita nodded and showed him her answer.

“Same.”

They returned to the next question. Her phone rested where both could read it, and they occasionally shifted their notebooks to make room on the little desks. Whenever he wanted a clearer view, he bent forward rather than moving his chair again. He had made one

journey across the classroom; there was no need to establish a transport service.

The thought brought a smile to his face.

"What?" Sanondita asked.

He looked up. "Hmm?"

She glanced at him, as though wondering what he had found amusing.

"Oh, nothing. Just remembered something."

She nodded and returned to her notebook. Utkarsh lowered his eyes, still smiling, and read the next problem. It involved percentages. Halfway through his calculation, he noticed that her pen had paused above an unfinished line.

"Is it this step?" he asked, indicating the part he thought she was considering.

"Hmm?"

"I mean, we have to take the percentage of the remaining amount, right? Not the original?"

She glanced at the PDF. "Yeah."

"That's what I thought."

He returned to his calculation, pleased to have said something useful. A minute later, his answer refused to match any of the options. He checked the multiplication, then the subtraction. Both were correct. He looked from the result to the screen.

"Are you getting any of these options?"

She studied his page. "You took twenty per cent here."

"Yeah."

"It's thirty."

He looked at the PDF. Thirty, written quite clearly. He crossed out the calculation.

"Right. That would explain the problem."

She resumed writing, and he began again. He was smiling despite himself. He had said something useful and then something foolish, and neither had required the conversation to end. Sanondita

had pointed out the error as simply as she had shown him the earlier step. He could correct it. He didn't need to account for every impression he might be making.

At the front, the teacher stopped writing.

"Everyone getting this?"

"Sir," Deepesh said from behind them, "the method is clear. The answer is creating some problems."

A few students laughed.

"The answer isn't creating problems," the teacher said. "You're creating problems."

That earned a louder laugh. Utkarsh lowered his head, grinning. When he glanced back, Deepesh gave him an exaggeratedly innocent expression. Utkarsh shook his head and faced the board again.

Everything was familiar: Deepesh's unnecessary remarks, the teacher's diminishing patience, the brief laughter before everyone returned to their notebooks. Only now, Sanondita was beside him. Utkarsh reached for his pen and noticed that his foot lay still on the floor. He couldn't remember when he had stopped holding it there. He was no longer arranging his arms each time she moved.

He followed the next question. When the teacher paused to consult his notes, Utkarsh turned slightly towards her.

"Do you come to both classes regularly?"

"Not always."

"Oh. Same here. I missed quite a few classes because of my college exams."

She nodded. He considered asking whether she preferred Arithmetic or Reasoning, then looked at the board. He had already asked about her graduation, her subject, and her attendance. There was a limit to how much information he could reasonably request from someone who had agreed to share a phone.

A minute later, he spoke again.

“Have you been preparing for these exams for long?”

She answered briefly. He was so occupied with finding a way to keep the conversation alive that he scarcely registered the answer.

“Right,” he said.

Sanondita was writing again, looking between the board and her notebook. He watched her for a moment, then lowered his eyes. He had wanted to know about her, yet he had barely listened when she told him something. She was here to study. The time he wished to fill belonged to her as well.

For several minutes, he kept quiet. The teacher explained another method, and Utkarsh followed it carefully enough to understand. He wrote the answer, checked it, and turned to the next page. Before this afternoon, he had sat within sight of Sanondita through entire classes without speaking. Now, a few silent minutes beside her seemed like an opportunity slipping away. He tried to let them pass without searching for another question.

The PDF remained open between them. He could read it, work, and stay where he was. When she moved to the next problem, he checked the screen.

“Is this the last step?”

She looked over. “No, one more.”

“Oh, right.”

He corrected the line and continued. This time, he let the silence return. It was pleasant to have a reason to sit there that required nothing more of either of them.

He first became aware of the time when the teacher glanced at the clock.

“We’ll do two more. The remaining questions you can practise at home.”

Someone at the back asked whether the answers would be shared in the group. The teacher replied that they already had enough material to practise without waiting for answers to everything, provoking a familiar murmur of protest. Utkarsh looked at the PDF.

There were still quite a few questions left. Without thinking about it, he had assumed they would continue until all of them were finished.

Now there were two.

He checked the clock and wished he hadn't. The first few minutes beside her had seemed impossibly long. Somewhere between the crossed-out answers and their whispered exchanges, they had become easy enough for him to stop counting. Soon she would put her phone away. They would pack their bags and leave, and the arrangement that had allowed him to remain beside her would be over.

He looked down at his notebook. Her number was not there. He could probably find it in one of the coaching WhatsApp groups, but he didn't want to begin another conversation by explaining how he had obtained it. He wanted to ask her. If she gave it to him, he could speak to her again without waiting for Diya to leave early, or for another PDF, or for a roomful of empty chairs to arrange themselves in his favour.

Can I have your number?

Five ordinary words. He had asked about her degree and her attendance without anything terrible happening. But those questions belonged to the afternoon. This one would admit that he wanted something to continue after it.

The teacher began the next problem. Utkarsh copied the first line and crossed out a figure he had just written. He imagined Sanondita looking puzzled.

Why?

It would be a reasonable question. He could say he wanted to stay in touch, but the plainness of that answer frightened him more than any elaborate excuse. Questions from class would sound safer. The official group already existed for those. He pressed the end of his pen against the notebook.

You could just ask politely. People are allowed to say no.

He knew that. It was the prospect of sitting there afterward that made him hesitate: their notebooks still open, her phone between them, and his wish to know her a little better no longer hidden beneath the lesson. He would have to thank her for helping and let the class end. She would have done nothing wrong. That wouldn't keep him from carrying the moment home.

"What's the answer?" the teacher asked.

Several students responded. Utkarsh recognised the number a second too late. The teacher nodded and moved to the final question.

A pen fell somewhere behind him. A phone vibrated against a writing tablet. He heard each small sound separately as he tried to estimate how much time remained. Five minutes, perhaps. Ten, if the last problem was difficult. For the first time he could remember, he hoped an Arithmetic question would require an unnecessarily lengthy explanation.

It did not. The marker moved across the board with irritating efficiency. Utkarsh glanced at Sanondita. She was following the solution, her pen poised above the page. He waited until she had finished writing, then found another reason to wait. The teacher circled the answer.

Someone asked about a step.

Utkarsh almost laughed with relief. While the explanation began again, he turned his pen between his fingers and watched her finish the line. Earlier, he had been frightened of beginning a conversation. Now he was allowing the last of it to pass because he was frightened of asking for another.

He leaned slightly towards her.

"Um, Sanondita…"

It was the first time he had addressed her by name. She looked up.

"Hmm?"

"Can I…"

He paused. The edge of the pen pressed into his finger. At the back of the room, a few students had begun putting away their notebooks. There was no better moment waiting for him.

“Can I have your phone number?”

For a second, he felt as though everyone must have heard. Sanondita looked at him. He kept his eyes on her, although he wanted to look down and give her some harmless explanation for the question before she could answer it.

“Yeah,” she said.

He blinked.

“Yeah?”

She nodded.

“Okay.”

He had prepared himself so thoroughly for refusal that agreement left him without a plan. A smile threatened to spread across his face. He tried to contain it and reached towards his pocket.

“Just a second.”

His fingers nearly reached the phone before he remembered. He stopped, then moved his hand towards the notebook instead.

“I forgot my phone,” he said. “As I told you.”

Yes. Remind her. Excellent strategy.

Sanondita waited. He turned a page, then another, suddenly dissatisfied with the fractions, crossed-out answers, and corrections occupying every available space. At last, he found a clear section near the bottom, beneath an unfinished calculation.

“Tell me.”

She began giving him the digits. He wrote carefully, conscious of each movement of the pen. He had spent the afternoon making mistakes in Arithmetic; now he wanted to be certain of ten numbers. When she finished, he counted them, then counted again.

“Can you repeat the last few?”

She did. He checked them against the page.

“Okay. Thank you.”

He wanted to say something more, but she returned her attention to the front. He looked down at the number. It occupied a little space beneath a calculation he had failed to complete, written in the same handwriting as everything around it. He stared until he realised he was smiling, then lowered his head.

She had simply said yes. He was relieved, and happy enough to feel embarrassed by how happy he was. Beside him, Sanondita was listening to the teacher’s final explanation. He had no reason to think the afternoon had meant anything unusual to her. The number did not tell him that. What it did tell him was that he had asked, and she had chosen to give it. He could stop wondering whether he would ever manage to speak to her. He had managed it, with a borrowed screen and considerably more trouble than necessary.

The teacher capped the marker.

“All right. That’s enough for today.”

Chairs began shifting. Sanondita reached for her phone, and Utkarsh moved his notebook aside so she could take it easily.

“Thanks,” he said again.

She nodded. He began packing, taking care not to fold the page where her number was written. His own phone remained in his pocket. He was leaving with it, a rather embarrassing secret, and ten digits he knew he would check again before going to sleep.

Then Sanondita stood, and he realised they were leaving at the same time.

Utkarsh rose a little too quickly. His chair scraped backward, and he caught the edge of the folding tablet before it could swing against his leg. Sanondita was adjusting her bag strap when he finally gathered his own things. He checked that the notebook was inside his bag, then checked again.

The number is not going to escape.

Students were comparing answers and discussing the next day. Deepesh was saying something to Nikita near the back; Tanisha caught Utkarsh’s eye and smiled. He looked away before she could

make anything of it. Sanondita went towards the door, and he followed at a natural distance, though he had begun to doubt his ability to judge what was natural.

The corridor was crowded with students from other classrooms. Someone called to a friend near the lift; a group talking by the wall obliged everyone else to move around them. Utkarsh and Sanondita reached the lift together. He pressed the button. Neither spoke while they waited. He watched the illuminated number above the doors change and wished, now, that the lift would take its time.

He had been waiting for the class to end so that he could stop worrying about the question he needed to ask. Having asked it, he found he wanted the afternoon to continue.

The lift arrived with a soft chime. They entered with a few other students, and he moved to one side to leave room. As the doors closed, he caught their reflection in the metal opposite. He had watched Sanondita from across the classroom for months, noticed her arrival, and rehearsed ways to speak to her. In the reflection, they looked like two students going home after class. He liked seeing himself beside her in so ordinary a way.

"Did you understand the last question?" he asked.

"Yeah. Mostly."

"I think I understood it until the final step."

She glanced towards him. "You can practise it from the PDF."

"Yeah. I will."

He suspected he would spend considerably more time examining her phone number than that particular problem. He kept the thought to himself.

The doors opened onto the ground-floor lobby. A few students lingered near the entrance; others were already walking away, bags over their shoulders. Utkarsh looked briefly for his friends and couldn't see them. Sanondita continued towards the exit, and he walked beside her.

Outside, Kolkata was carrying on with its afternoon. A horn sounded behind them, followed by another, more impatient one. People passed in both directions or stopped near the shops. The air was warm; the pavement held the accumulated dust of the day. Utkarsh knew this road, its uneven places and the usual congestion near the crossing. He knew where he would turn. He found himself noticing how quickly other people passed them, and how often they had to adjust their steps to make room.

They talked about their studies. Later, he wouldn't have been able to repeat the conversation word for word. He remembered mentioning his final-semester exams and waiting for the results. He remembered her answering a question about preparation. The traffic interrupted them occasionally; they resumed a few steps later. This time, he listened to what she said without trying to prepare his next question before she had finished.

There were pauses. He had feared them throughout the class. Outside, they were easier. They walked a little way without speaking, and Sanondita didn't appear to be waiting for him to entertain her. He could keep pace beside her and look ahead. After all the effort of finding something to say, it was a relief to discover that they did not need to be talking every second.

Their roads would separate soon. He recognised the place ahead and felt the remaining distance shorten. He had her number; he could message about a question, perhaps, or ask whether she was coming to class. Nevertheless, he didn't want to say goodbye. He slowed slightly, then corrected himself. There was no reason to make her walk more slowly simply because he wished the road were longer.

At the point where their directions divided, Sanondita stopped. Utkarsh stopped too. Their conversation had reached its natural end.

"Will you come tomorrow?"

He had meant to ask casually. He had asked his friends the same question often enough, without listening so closely for the answer. Now he could hear the hope in his voice and hoped she hadn't.

Sanondita considered it. "Not sure."

"Oh. Okay."

He waited, as though she might add some small certainty. But she had answered. There was nothing she needed to add.

"All right… Bye."

"Bye."

She turned towards her road. Utkarsh took a step in the opposite direction, then stopped and looked back. She was making her way through the people on the pavement, her bag against her side. A pedestrian passed between them. He lost sight of her for a moment, then found her farther along.

She hadn't looked back.

He knew there was no reason she should. Still, some small part of him had hoped she might, and he smiled at himself for it. He had spoken to her for most of a class, walked beside her, and received her number. Already he wanted another afternoon. He wanted to know what she liked talking about beyond exams, whether she laughed easily with people she knew well, whether she enjoyed coming to coaching. He wanted answers to questions he hadn't yet earned the familiarity to ask.

She continued down the pavement. The ordinary way she walked away was difficult to reconcile with everything he was carrying from their conversation. She had been friendly, had helped him, and had given him a way to contact her. He tried to remember that without asking her brief goodbye to mean more. When the movement of the street made her difficult to distinguish from everyone else, he turned and began walking towards home.

He tried to think about the route ahead and whether he had work to finish that evening. Instead, he remembered her turning when he nudged her with his pen, then the chair he had dragged across the

floor as though standing up would have been the more embarrassing choice. He laughed quietly. A man passing glanced at him, and Utkarsh straightened his face. A few steps later, he was smiling again.

Then he remembered the number.

He stopped near the edge of the pavement and opened his bag. The notebook was exactly where he had put it. He found the page and read the ten digits, then read them again. He had received phone numbers before, saved contacts without thinking, replied to classmates days late when he was busy. Now he was standing beside a road, smiling at a notebook.

He took out his phone—the phone he had supposedly left at home—and shook his head.

You are never telling anyone how this happened.

He entered the digits carefully, checked them against the page, and saved the contact under her name.

Sanondita.

He looked at it among the other names. For months, hers had been a name he heard from other people and kept to himself. Now it was on his screen because he had asked her, and she had answered. He didn't send a message or call. He closed the notebook, put everything away, and continued walking.

The traffic was as impatient as before, the pavement as uneven. Nobody passing could have guessed that anything had happened to him. He was glad, somehow, to have a little time in which he did not need to explain it. He could remember her pointing to a calculation, asking what he studied, moving the phone so that he could see. Each moment had actually happened. He no longer had to invent both sides of the conversation.

She still didn't know his name.

The thought arrived so abruptly that he stopped smiling. He had asked hers. She had asked what he studied. They had talked through much of the class, exchanged a number, taken the lift, and walked

outside together. At some point, he had intended to say I'm Utkarsh, by the way. Somehow, that point had never come.

He stared ahead, then began laughing, helplessly enough to lower his head.

Brilliant, Utkarsh. Absolutely brilliant.

He imagined telling Tanisha. He could practically hear her laugh. After months of hoping Sanondita might notice him, he had finally spoken to her and neglected to introduce himself. He would have to tell her eventually. Tomorrow, perhaps, if she came. Another day, if she didn't. The prospect no longer frightened him quite as much.

He turned onto the familiar road towards home. Not sure, she had said. He could remember the answer without changing it into a promise. For now, he had her name in his phone and a conversation to remember. Whenever he thought of her turning towards him in the classroom, the smile returned.

He didn't know whether she would come tomorrow. He only knew that he would be looking for her.